

US arms stockpile concerns will outlast Iran conflict

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US interceptor gaps deepen Iran standoff but have limited Taiwan effect

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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Depleted interceptors limit any renewed US offensive operation against Iran to a matter of weeks, consistent with the base case of protracted standoff (60% odds).

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A US decision to resume offensive action would force reliance on shorter-range, higher-risk systems and expand regional operations, raising the risk to US personnel and facilities.

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Shortfalls will drive defense budget debates for years but are less constraining for a Taiwan contingency than media coverage suggests, as "attritable mass" reduces dependence on the interceptors now in short supply.

Budget request acrimony will make interceptor replenishment more challenging. The bulk of the Pentagon's interceptor replenishment is structured to be funded under a \$350 billion reconciliation package. However, given political dynamics in both chambers of Congress, such a package is all but off the table (see: Defense spending increase likely to fall short of record topline 23 April 2026). Both the House and Senate have pivoted to seeking smaller supplemental packages to fund replenishment efforts, ranging from \$60 billion to \$87.8 billion, well below the Pentagon's requested levels. Funding is just part of the issue; supply chain constraints will create long lead times for missile orders regardless of funding levels authorized this year. The Trump administration has moved to boost future production through framework deals with major defense contractors. Under peacetime assumptions, these agreements could replenish stocks to pre-war levels by 2029-2030 and expand US stocks to the Pentagon's new requirements by the mid-2030s—though the annual funding reauthorization requirements will constrain industry capital investment in production expansion. The Pentagon will likely push to restructure procurement contracts into multi-year agreements to address this, but congressional approval is not guaranteed. These framework deals will likely accelerate production if backed by multi-year funding authorization, but facility modifications, supply chain rearrangement, and workforce expansion will still take years before target production rates are reached. Co-production arrangements face the same structural constraints as domestic production lines in the near term and will not provide a quick fix for current shortfalls.

Depleted stocks limit, but do not preclude, US escalation against Iran. Defensive systems like the Terminal High Altitude Area Defense (THAAD) and Patriot interceptors have been depleted per public reporting, limiting the duration of any renewed US operation—which would bring increased Iranian counter-strikes—likely to a period of weeks. These limitations on US offensive actions contribute to our basecase (60% odds) of protracted standoff in Iran (see: Standoff now likely to run through 2026 as Hormuz traffic increases , 1 September 2026). The exact status of US interceptor stockpiles is classified, and public reports reflect either deductive analysis of usage and replenishment or selective leaks. The former can assess global stocks roughly but does not offer a clear view of systems actually deployed in the conflict zone. The latter reflects the source offering the information, and the most dire estimates of remaining stocks may be driven by those publicly advocating against renewed combat.

Weapons shortfalls may force tactical changes that add risk to renewed US operations. The US has favored long-range precision weapons in the conflict, both to avoid risk to US assets and servicemembers and to allow greater flexibility in target selection and strike timing. This posture reduces short-term logistical complexity but narrows the menu of options for commanders in the operational zone. With long-range precision weapons in shorter supply, the US is not precluded from offensive action (25% odds) but will face additional risks relying on systems—such as Maneuver Short Range Air Defense (M-SHORAD) and manned tactical aircraft—that are in greater supply. The support infrastructure needed to sustain these capabilities would require an expansion of regional operations, increasing the risk posed to US personnel and facilities. Still, the dearth of high-end air defense munitions constrains escalatory options—including the deployment of ground forces—absent a dramatic change in President Donald Trump's risk tolerance for American casualties.

Interceptor shortfalls will constrain US global posture but leave Taiwan strategy less exposed than expected. Concerns about depleted US stockpiles are unlikely to fade quickly and will be a key argument for continued increases in defense spending. The issue will also factor into the US's ability—or perceived ability—to project force globally, potentially limiting US influence and incentivizing more opportunistic actors. In part, these concerns are well founded: the US is unlikely to innovate away its dependence on expensive, high-end air defense interceptors in the near future. However, the interceptor shortfall will not constrain operations in a potential Taiwan contingency in the zero-sum manner that some media coverage suggests. Where the US now favors a long-range strike posture in Iran dependent on targeted strikes, a future Taiwan contingency would most likely favor a US arsenal ordered around a mix of precision munitions alongside “attributable mass” —distributed, expendable autonomous systems and cheap munitions designed to deny adversary aims and raise the cost of escalation. This organizing principle will alter interceptor use. By distributing large amounts of cheap, replaceable systems across the operational area, commanders can pull high-end platforms back from the front line. Repositioning these platforms, in turn, reduces the exposure of operating facilities to attack and, relatedly, the number of interceptors needed to protect them. Correspondingly, the impacts of shortfalls will diminish as US force composition shifts toward a Taiwan contingency posture, and as production arrangements expand.

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